especially with Aurangzeb, a puritanical man.[20] Selective razing and replacement of temples with mosques hurt the political standing of rival Hindu kings, but it often also signalled that the top dog was now Islam. In that non-secular, non-democratic age, most Muslim rulers patronized Islam more than Hinduism (and vice versa)—state funding to temples and Brahmins declined relative to pre-Islamic times. Though a minority population, 'Muslims numerically dominated the corps of the Mughal elite'.[21] Muslim rulers also levied jizya, a tax on non-Muslims (it exceeded *zakat*, a tax on better-off Muslims). Discriminatory and widely resented, jizya was poorly collected in practice, especially in villages where most Hindus lived, and it often only lined the pockets of the tax collectors. Akbar abolished jizya in 1579. A hundred years later, despite opposition from his nobles and family, Aurangzeb revived it for forty more years. The Brahmins, however, got their own class exempted from jizya all along.

Such adverse policies and shifts in patronage likely dampened Varanasi's Brahminical culture more than temple desecrations (averaging once in a few generations). Unintentionally, this 'may have encouraged the spread of new, more popular forms of Hinduism such as bhakti', writes historian Wendy Doniger.[22] Popular forms paid scant attention to sectarian boundaries. Wandering 'gurus, pirs and sants' of all backgrounds preached 'a religious melange that defied identification with a particular religion'.[23] Alongside, a rich new high culture arose too. An early example is that of Sufi poet Amir Khusrau, whose Turkish father—a refugee from Samarkand after Genghis Khan had ravaged it—had married the daughter of a Rajput noble and minister in the Delhi Sultanate. Khusrau was only eight when his father died; he then grew up in his mother's Rajput family in Delhi. He would later fuse multiple traditions to create qawwali music and introduce the ghazal in India. In the ensuing centuries, a syncretic Indo-Persian fusion culture arose in cities across India, including Varanasi. Its many legacies pervade modern Indian culture in art, architecture, literature, music, dance, cuisine, dress, painting, crafts, etc. Varanasi's musical syncretism, for instance, would later make the city central to the evolution of Hindustani vocal styles like Thumri, Dadra and Tappa, and produce maestros like Bismillah Khan, Ravi Shankar and Girija Devi.